

based, multi-span mobile bridging systems—in high altitude areas for the first time. With projects like these, the Indian military has improved its battle readiness along the border with China, where essential items such as arms, ammunition and food have to be transported up in bulk before winter, with its sub-zero temperatures, sets in. As the situation on the Himalayan frontier turns 'stable' but 'unpredictable' according to military experts, there is very little choice but to up one's game. Military planners claim rapid infrastructure development has enhanced the Indian military's capability—for example, a majority of the army's company-level posts are now connected to roads.

Multiple standoffs along the LAC have certainly injected an urgency in the building and bulking up of border infrastructure. In December 2021, defence minister Rajnath Singh inaugurated three roads and 24 bridges, mostly built for faster access to the LAC. Ladakh's Chisumle-Demchok Road is today the world's highest motorable road. The 52 km-long road passes through the Umling La pass at an altitude of 19,000 feet, connecting the towns in the Chumar sector of Eastern Ladakh, directly connecting Chisumle and Demchok with Leh as well as the Nyoma and Karu military stations. Nine new tunnels are also under construction in the area, including the strategic 2.5-km-long Sela tunnel near Tawang at an altitude of 13,000 feet, which will be the highest bi-lane tunnel in the world once completed.

The lion's share of the work on the China border is undertaken by the Border Roads Organisation (BRO), the agency under the defence ministry. In the past five years, BRO has constructed 3,595 km of roads, primarily along the LAC, to facilitate all-weather access to forward areas at an overall cost of Rs 20,767 crore. In a reply to Parliament in the previous session, the MoD stated that 2,089 km of roads were constructed along the China border at a cost of Rs 15,477 crore.

Moreover, the Rs 12,000 crore Char Dham highway project that aims to connect four Hindu shrines—Gangotri, Yamunotri, Kedarnath and Badrinath—in the Garhwal region of Uttarakhand will also bolster connectivity to the LAC. The defence ministry wants to construct connecting links from army and Indo-Tibetan Border Police stations located in Joshimath, Uttarkashi, Roorkee, Rajwala, Dehradun, Tanakpur, Pithoragarh and other places on the proposed highway to the LAC.

Besides creating modern habitat in the past two years to accommodate 22,000 troops, the Indian military has set up 20 Solar Heated Insulated Ladakhi